Eidgenössische Technische Hochschule Zürich
Swiss Federal Institute of Technology Zurich

Disney RESEARCH STUDIOS

Game Technology Center

Bachelor Thesis Project Description

Controllable Storytelling for Interactive AI Characters

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Introduction

State-of-the-art real-time AI characters can interact with users in believable and engaging ways. However, existing systems often deviate from the intended story when users interrupt or ask unexpected questions and they do not address the constraint of completing a story within a bounded time window. This thesis addresses these limitations by exploring LLM-based narrative planning and goal-directed control strategies within fixed time budgets in the context of an existing AI character pipeline.

Task Description

- Familiarize yourself with controllable storytelling for interactive AI characters and our internal AI character pipeline.
- Implement a method that constrains the storytelling in a controllable way. For example, constraining story generation based on user inputs, the current beat within the story arc and the remaining time to tell the story.
- Thoroughly evaluate the method on several storytelling scenarios and run a user study for human evaluation.

Milestones

Description	Date
Thesis start	13 April 2026
Literature Review	April 2026
Storytelling Baseline Implementation	May 2026
Extension to the Baseline	May/July 2026
Evaluation	July/August 2026
Writing the thesis	August/September 2026
Hand-in final report	31 October 2026
Thesis presentation	28 September 2026

Remarks

A written report and an oral presentation conclude the thesis. The thesis will be overseen by Dr. Fabio Zünd, Prof. Robert W. Sumner and supervised by Dr. Christopher Otto and Dr. Steven Poulakos.